Q+A

Danseuse with a Difference

KATHAK MAESTRO AND PADMA SHRI RECIPIENT **SHOVANA NARAYAN** ON HER NEW DANCE PRODUCTION, *ANUTTAR*, AND MORE



Q. What is the thought behind your dance production *Anuttar*?

Through its three acts–'Akhir Kyon', 'Shakuni' and 'Toota Yeh Vishwas Kyon'–*Anuttar* subtly stirs the collective consciousness of society. It highlights the struggles faced by women, the girl child and marginalised LGBTQ+ sections of society, especially the trans community.

Q. Haven't social themes been central to your dance productions from the beginning of your career?

In 1982, I presented a dance on environmental degradation when nobody even discussed the issue. I have also covered themes like bonded labour and abuse of women in my work. The approach isn't sermonising, yet it sends a strong message to the audience.

Q. What's your take on the representation of kathak in Indian cinema?

It pains me to see the Techno Kathak of today. The reach of Bollywood is much more and it's quicker too. When you show them something repeatedly, people will believe it. For instance, kathak in Indian films has always been shown to happen in *kothas* (pleasure houses). Even in its most traditional format, it's a living temple dance form.

Q. What will be your next steps?

Kathak has been my language of expression since I was three years old. I don't follow trends but take up things that affect me deeply. Besides my production *Anuttar*, I have a packed calendar with shows in multiple cities. *Ramayana in World Art and Thought*, an anthology edited by me with contributions by 16 eminent writers, was published in February.

–with Geetika Sachdev

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